Country Report
Morocco

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Morocco Country Report

National AI Strategy

Currently, Morocco lacks a National AI Strategy. While discussions have taken place in forums like the MoroccoAI conference, organized by a non-governmental agency, proposing a framework for such a strategy, it has yet to be formally adopted by the Government.[1] The Digital Development Agency (ADD) intends to establish "an ecosystem dedicated to Artificial Intelligence," which is seen as the pathway for the development of the National AI Strategy.[2]

In December 2018, the Mohamed VI Polytechnic University in Morocco hosted UNESCO's first Forum on AI in Africa.[3] This led to the creation of the Benguérir Declaration,[4] advocating for the advancement of an AI Strategy across the African continent.[5] The declaration emphasized "the importance of fostering AI in Africa as a catalyst for development, focusing on the human rights aspect and grounded in universal ethical principles."[6] Following the forum, Morocco allocated 50 million MAD to finance research projects in 11 specific areas related to AI.[7]

The "AL KHAWARIZMI" program was launched in May 2019 through a partnership between the Digital Development Agency (ADD) and the National Center for Scientific and Technical Research (CNRST), in partnership with the Ministry of Industry, Trade, and the Green and Digital Economy (MICEVN), as well as the Ministry of National Education, Vocational Training, Higher Education, and Scientific Research (MENFPESRC).[8] This initiative supports applied research projects in the realms of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Big Data. Its objective is to promote and incentivize applied scientific research within the digital development domain, aligning with the ADD's vision for advancing the AI ecosystem.

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[1] Morocco AI, Recommendations Towards a National AI Strategy for Morocco (October 2023), https://morocco.ai/
[2] Digital Development Agency, Ecosystem Dedicated to Artificial Intelligence (2021), https://www.add.gov.ma/ecosysteme-dedie-a-lintelligence-artificielle-prioritaire
[3] UNESCO, Artificial Intelligence Needs Assessment Survey in Africa (2021), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000375322
[4] UNESCO, Outcome Statement of the Forum on Artificial Intelligence in Africa - Benguérir (Kingdom of Morocco) (13 December 2018), https://en.unesco.org/sites/default/files/ai_outcome-statement_africa-forum_en.pdf
[5] UNESCO, Artificial Intelligence Needs Assessment Survey in Africa (2021), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000375322
[6] UNESCO, Artificial Intelligence Needs Assessment Survey in Africa (2021), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000375322
[7] UNESCO, Steering AI and advanced ICTs for knowledge societies: a Rights, Openness, Access, and Multi-stakeholder Perspective (2019), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000372132
[8] Digital Development Agency, Al-Khawarizmi Program (2023), https://www.add.gov.ma/programme-al-khawarizmi

The Euromed University of Fez (UEMF) inaugurated the Euromed School of Digital Engineering and Artificial Intelligence (EIDIA), a specialized institution focusing on AI research, development, and education.[9] It stands as the first Engineering School entirely dedicated to Digital Engineering and Artificial Intelligence (EIDIA) within the Euro-Mediterranean-African Space, marking a significant milestone in the region's academic landscape.[10]

Public Participation

Although specific public participation opportunities for the development of Morocco's AI Strategy were not identified, the formulation of The New Development Model for Morocco, which outlines the country's vision until 2035,[11] employed a comprehensive consultative process and co-construction approach. Artificial intelligence is highlighted in the report as a disruptive force, emphasizing the necessity for adequate training in this field. However, it remains unclear whether a similar process will be adopted for the development of the National AI Strategy.

The MoroccoAI Annual conference serves as another platform for businesses, government entities, and civil society to convene in Morocco.[12] The Recommendations Towards a National AI Strategy for Morocco Report is derived from an analysis of numerous National AI Strategies and the priorities delineated in Morocco's New Development Model (NDM). This report meticulously presents 44 recommendations tailored to the development of an AI strategy for Morocco,[13] shedding light on critical areas where AI has the potential to significantly advance Morocco's developmental goals.

Data Protection

Law No. 09-08 on the Protection of Individuals with Regard to the Processing of Personal Data (Law No. 09-08) was passed in 2009.[14] This law establishes a framework for safeguarding personal data, and the Data Protection National Commission (CNDP) possesses the authority to issue guidance and enforce its provisions.[15] Presently, the CNDP is engaged

[9] Morocco World News, Artificial Intelligence School to Open in Fez (12 July 2019), https://www.moroccoworldnews.com/2019/07/278026/artificial-intelligence-school-open-fe
[10] Smail Tigani, Digital Engineering and Artificial Intelligence Platform (2020), https://ueuromed.org/en/plateformes-technnologiques/digital-engineering-and-artificial-intelligence-platform
[11] Special Commission for the Development Model, The New Development Model – General Report (April 2021), https://www.csmd.ma/documents/CSMD_Report_EN.pdf
[12] MoroccoAI Conferences and Workshops, MoroccoAI (2023) https://morocco.ai/conference/
[13] MoroccoAI, Recommendations Towards a National AI Strategy for Morocco (October 2023), https://morocco.ai/
[14] DLA Piper, Data Protection Laws of the World – Morocco (8 January 2019), https://www.dlapiperdataprotection.com/system/modules/za.co.heliosdesign.dla.lotw.data_protection/functions/handbook.pdf?country-1=MA
[15] OneTrust DataGuidance, Morocco – Data Protection Overview (July 2023), https://www.dataguidance.com/notes/morocco-data-protection-overview

in the process of revising the law to ensure alignment with global standards and potentially seek EU adequacy status.[16]

Since 2013, the processing of biometric data has been governed by the provisions outlined in CNDP Decision no. 478-2013, which delineates the necessary conditions for the utilization of biometric devices for access control.[17] This decision establishes regulations for the handling of biometric data and mandates prior authorization from the CNDP for the installation of such devices. However, authorization for the use of biometric data in accessing “sensitive premises and facilities” is granted under specific conditions.

In September 2019, the CNDP imposed a moratorium on facial recognition[18] by both public and private organizations, extending it until the end of 2020[19] through Deliberation D-195-EUS/2020, which stipulates the requirement of CNDP authorization among other criteria.[20] Notably, in 2020, biometric systems were sanctioned by the CNDP for utilization in "user authentication and proof of life for social welfare beneficiaries" by social security institutions.

In 2020, Morocco released two opinions regarding the utilization of facial recognition technologies. These publications underscored the country's meticulous approach in reconciling technological progress with the protection of data rights and ethical concerns.[21] Additionally, Morocco collaborated with Burkina Faso in co-sponsoring AI-related resolutions at the Global Privacy Assembly. Furthermore, Morocco joined other data protection authorities in co-signing a letter addressing concerns related to data scraping.[22]

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[16] Konrad-Adenauer-Stiftung e. V. Rule of Law Programme MENA, Data Protection Laws in Northern Africa (September 2022), https://www.kas.de/documents/265308/22468903/230406_DataProtectionLawsNorthernAfrica_KAS_Web.pdf/

[17] Mehdi Kettani, Morocco: Data Protection & Cybersecurity (2023), https://www.legal500.com/guides/chapter/morocco-data-protection-cybersecurity/

[18] BiometricUpdate.com, Morocco places moratorium on facial recognition, California limits police use (12 September 2019), https://www.biometricupdate.com/201909/morocco-places-moratorium-on-facial-recognition-california-limits-police-use

[19] BiometricUpdate.com, Morocco extends facial recognition moratorium to year-end, proposes biometric authentication service (9 April 2020), https://www.biometricupdate.com/202004/morocco-extends-facial-recognition-moratorium-to-year-end-proposes-biometric-authentication-service

[20] Mehdi Kettani, Morocco: Data Protection & Cybersecurity (2023), https://www.legal500.com/guides/chapter/morocco-data-protection-cybersecurity/

[21] Tech Hive Advisory - Center for Law & Innovation. State of AI Regulation in Africa: Trends and Developments Report. March 2024. https://media.licdn.com/dms/document/media/D4E1FAQGBx8pDXKQ-sA/feedshare-document-pdf-analyzed/0/1710863047549?e=1711584000&v=beta&t=aUm2HJrbzXxcuwbl3e0NaNd3kvgsjmQ5X6FRtOQ_z3U

[22] Tech Hive Advisory - Center for Law & Innovation. State of AI Regulation in Africa: Trends and Developments Report. March 2024. https://media.licdn.com/dms/document/media/D4E1FAQGBx8pDXKQ-sA/feedshare-document-pdf-analyzed/0/1710863047549?e=1711584000&v=beta&t=aUm2HJrbzXxcuwbl3e0NaNd3kvgsjmQ5X6FRtOQ_z3U

Furthermore, a consultation regarding genomic data was initiated in April 2022.[23]

Morocco is an active member of the Network of African Data Protection Authorities (NADPA).[24] This network serves as a platform for facilitating exchanges and cooperation among its members, aiming to amplify Africa's voice in its engagements with partners worldwide.[25]

Its recent focus has been on "strengthening the network's international presence, promoting legislation on Data Protection across Africa, and fostering cooperation among members, including capacity building."[26] In 2022, the NADPA signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Smart Africa Alliance to collaborate on various issues. These include supporting the enforcement of data protection regulations, advocating for the establishment of a harmonized framework for data protection policies and regulations across Africa, and assisting countries in drafting or revising legislation and establishing Data Protection Authorities (DPAs).[27]

Algorithmic Transparency

Article 11 of Law No. 09-08 prohibits decision-making based on the automated processing of personal data.[28] In October 2018, the Council of Europe treaty, Convention 108, officially titled the Convention for the Protection of Individuals with regard to Automatic Processing of Personal Data, was signed by 20 states.[29] Morocco, along with two other countries, was invited to accede to the treaty. Accession involves a formal evaluation to ensure that the relevant laws of the applicant country meet the requirements outlined in Convention 108.[30]

[23] CNDP, Protection of Genomic Data (19 April 2022), https://www.cndp.ma/images/commpresse/CNDP-Consultations_GENOME_20220419-EN.pdf
[24] DiploFoundation, Stronger Digital Voices from Africa – Building African Digital Foreign Policy and Diplomacy (November 2022), https://www.diplomacy.edu/wp-content/uploads/2023/01/African-digital-foreign-policy_En.pdf

[25] NADPA/RAPDP, Who are we? (2023) https://www.nadpa-rapdp.org/en/qui-sommes-nous
[26] Global Privacy Assembly, International Enforcement Cooperation Working Group – Privacy and Data Protection Networks – Snapshot (13 May 2021), https://globalprivacyassembly.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/09/20210513-DPA-networks-Landscape-Snapshot-Infographic-1.0.pdf
[27] DiploFoundation, Stronger Digital Voices from Africa – Building African Digital Foreign Policy and Diplomacy
(November 2022), https://www.diplomacy.edu/wp-content/uploads/2023/01/African-digital-foreign-policy_En.pdf
[28] The National Commission for the Protection of Personal Data, Law No. 09-08 on the Protection of Individuals with Regard to the Processing of Personal Data (2009), https://www.cndp.ma/fr/cndp/publications.html
[29] IAPP, What does the newly signed 'Convention 108+' mean for UK adequacy? (30 October 2018), https://iapp.org/news/a/what-does-the-newly-signed-convention-108-mean-for-u-k-adequacy/#
[30] Graham Greenleaf, Data Protection Convention 108 Accession Eligibility: 80 Parties Now Possible (1 November 2017), https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=3062415

In May 2019, Morocco signed Convention 108[31] and its Protocol (CETS No. 223) amending the convention, thereby becoming the 55th State and the 6th country in the African region to do so.[32] These agreements came into force on September 1, 2019.

In 2021, the National Commission for Control of Personal Data Protection of Morocco (CNDP) and the Council of Europe announced a "Neighbourhood Partnership," which is a cooperation program aimed at promoting the ratification of the Protocol modernizing Convention 108, as well as supporting the CNDP's efforts to enhance data protection in the Kingdom of Morocco.[33]

Digital ID

Morocco established its national electronic identity system back in 2008,[34] introducing the CNIE (Carte Nationale d'Identité Electronique), a smart ID card equipped with cutting-edge security features. Enrollment procedures included biometric data capture to ensure the uniqueness of individuals, employing an Automatic Fingerprint Identification System (AFIS) for de-duplication.

In 2022, the Digital Development Agency (ADD) and the Directorate of National Security (DGSN) collaborated to launch an identification and authentication service for digital service users. This initiative enables individuals to verify their identities when accessing services from both public and private sectors.[35] Holders of the new National Electronic Identity card, introduced in 2019, gained immediate access to the platform, while holders of the old CNIE were also granted access.[36]

In June 2023, a tripartite agreement was announced between the Ministries of Health and Social Protection, the National Security Directorate, and the National Commission for the Control of Personal Data Protection. This agreement aimed to utilize the national identity card to simplify and enhance access to health services.[37] Hospitals and other medical facilities

[31] OneTrust DataGuidance, International: Morocco signs Convention 108 and amending Protocol (29 May 2019), https://www.dataguidance.com/news/international-morocco-signs-convention-108-and-amending
[32] Council of Europe, Welcome of Morocco, 55th State Party to Convention 108 (28 May 2019), https://www.coe.int/en/web/data-protection/-/welcome-to-morocco-55th-state-party-to-convention-108-
[33] Council of Europe, Support to data protection in Morocco (11 March 2021), https://www.coe.int/en/web/data-protection/support-to-data-protection-in-morocco
[34] World Bank Group, ID4D Country Diagnostic: Morocco (July 2014), https://id4d.worldbank.org/sites/id4d/files/2018-04/Morocco_ID4D_Diagnostic_Web404018.pdf
[35] Idemia, The Kingdom of Morocco launches a national digital ID platform with IDEMIA, (19 May 2022), https://www.idemia.com/news/kingdom-morocco-launches-national-digital-id-platform-idemia-2022-05-19
[36] Sara Zouiten, Digital ID: Moroccans to Access Multitude of Services Online (26 April 2022), https://www.moroccoworldnews.com/2022/04/348615/digital-id-moroccans-to-access-multitude-of-services-online
[37] Middle East Online, National card's digital ID: a convention for health (16 June 2023), https://middle-east-online.com/en/national-card%E2%80%99s-digital-id-convention-health

would be empowered to verify patient identities, and citizens would have the option to include certain health data in the electronic chip embedded within the national identity card.[38]

Significant AI Developments for the Period of Data Collection

Morocco has demonstrated its dedication to scientific advancement and ethical AI practices through several accomplishments in the field of artificial intelligence (AI). Morocco signed Convention 108 and the Protocol (CETS No. 223) in 2019,[39] marking the beginning of the journey and making it the sixth country in Africa and the 55th state overall. Morocco's commitment to data protection and the right to privacy—two crucial components in the AI landscape—was confirmed by this milestone.

The Digital Development Agency (ADD) and other relevant government agencies introduced the "AL KHAWARIZMI" program that same year.[40] This program encourages innovation and scientific research in line with the nation's AI ecosystem by supporting applied research projects in AI and Big Data. By endorsing the UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence in 2021, Morocco built upon these foundations and showed its dedication to advancing moral values and human rights in the creation and application of AI.[41] Morocco is taking the lead in responsible AI governance, as evidenced by the announcement made in 2022 by the Minister Delegate for Digital Transformation and Administrative Reform of the establishment of a committee to carry out the recommendations made around AI ethics.[42]

Morocco demonstrated its active commitment to addressing privacy concerns and encouraging responsible AI innovation on a global scale by co-sponsoring the 45th Global Privacy Assembly resolution on generative AI systems in June 2023.[43] Furthermore, in December 2023, a government AI Readiness Index showing Morocco's capacity to use AI technology placed the nation among the top five African countries,

[38] Biometricupdate.com, Morocco will introduce digital IDs into health services (22 June 2023), https://www.biometricupdate.com/202306/morocco-will-introduce-digital-ids-into-health-services
[39] One Trust Data Guidance, *International: Morocco signs Convention 108 and amending Protocol* (29 May 2019), https://www.dataguidance.com/news/international-morocco-signs-convention-108-and-amending
[40] Digital Development Agency, Al-Khawarizmi Program (2023), https://www.add.gov.ma/programme-alkhawarizmi
[41] UNESCO, UNESCO Member States Adopt the First Ever Global Agreement on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence (April 21, 2022), https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/unesco-member-states-adopt-first-everglobal-agreement-ethics-artificial-intelligence
[42] Oumaima Latrech, Morocco, UNESCO Pledge to Strengthen Artificial Intelligence Ethics (March 26, 2022), https://www.moroccoworldnews.com/2022/03/347908/morocco-unesco-pledge-to-strengthen-artificialintelligence-ethics
[43] Global Privacy Assembly, Resolution on Generative Artificial Intelligence Systems (October 2023), https://globalprivacyassembly.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/5.-Resolution-on-Generative-AI-Systems-101023.pdf

confirming Morocco's advancement in this area.[44] The "AI Movement" at Mohamed VI Polytechnic University of Morocco was acknowledged internationally in November 2023 when it was named a Category II university center by UNESCO,[45] highlighting the university's popularity as a regional hub for AI expertise and technical support.[46] As a sign of its active involvement in international AI governance and policy discussions, Morocco introduced the first-ever UN General Assembly resolution on the use of artificial intelligence in March 2024, along with the United States of America.[47]

Together, these advancements show Morocco's proactive approach to using AI to advance society and the economy and establish the country as a major force in the regional and international AI arena.

Lethal Autonomous Weapons

Morocco is a member of the Group of Government Experts on Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (GGE on Laws)[48] of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW) of the UN Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) since 2014. Ethical concerns led the group to declare a pre-emptive ban on LAWS.[49]

The Political Declaration on the Responsible Military Use of Artificial Intelligence and Autonomy has received Morocco's endorsement.[50] "To build international consensus around responsible behavior and guide states' development, deployment, and use of military AI," reads the declaration's stated goal. As of right now, Morocco is the only nation in North Africa to have ratified the Declaration.

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[44] Morocco Among Top 5 African Countries in Terms of AI Readiness (December 2023), https://www.moroccoworldnews.com/2023/12/359773/morocco-among-top-5-african-countries-in-terms-of-ai-readiness

[45] Category 2 Institutes and Centres, proposals for designation, Part II: Moroccan International Centre for Artificial Intelligence (AI Movement), Morocco (November 2023), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000386790_eng

[46] Morocco's Ai Movement-UM6P Receives UNESCO Category II Status in Paris (November 2023), https://www.moroccoworldnews.com/2023/11/358958/moroccos-ai-movement-um6p-receives-unesco-category-ii-status-in-paris

[47] UNGA: U.S and Moroccan Ambassadors Present First-Ever UN Resolution on Artificial Intelligence (Mars 2024), https://www.maroc.ma/en/news/unga-us-and-moroccan-ambassadors-present-first-ever-un-resolution-artificial-intelligence

[48] Automated Decision Research, Morocco (2023), https://automatedresearch.org/news/state_position/morocco/

[49] Congressional Research Service, International Discussions Concerning Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (14 February 2023), https://sgp.fas.org/crs/weapons/IF11294.pdf

[50] US Department of State, Political Declaration on Responsible Military Use of Artificial Intelligence and Autonomy (1 November 2023) https://www.state.gov/political-declaration-on-responsible-military-use-ofartificial-intelligence-and-autonomy/

Human Rights

Freedom House scored Morocco as partly-free country (37/100) in 2024.[51] Freedom House reported, "Morocco holds regular multiparty elections for Parliament and local bodies. Reforms in 2011 shifted some authority over government from the monarchy to the national legislature. Nevertheless, King Mohammed VI and his palace maintain full dominance through a combination of substantial formal powers and informal lines of influence in state and society." Morocco scored 53/100 for net freedom.[52] The Ibrahim Index of African Governance in 2021 scored Morocco at 61.5/100 for Overall Governance, and 48.8/100 in Participation, Rights & Inclusion, placing the country in position 10 out of 54 African countries, with an increasing trend since 2012.[53]

Morocco ratified the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR).[54] Morocco is a member of the Arab League but has not ratified the Arab Charter on Human Rights.[55] Other UN human rights treaties that Morocco has ratified are: International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR); the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR); the Convention against Torture and Other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment (CAT); the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW); the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD); the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC); the Convention for the Protection of all Persons from Enforced Disappearance (CED); the International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination (CERD); and the International Convention on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of Their Families (CMW).[56]

Footnotes 44 and 45: Amend hyperlink (https://freedomhouse.org/country/morocco/freedom-world/2023) to reflect Freedom in the World 2024 report: https://freedomhouse.org/country/morocco/freedom-world/2024

→ Justification: Freedom House updated their reports for 2024. No other changes necessary, as all other Freedom House scores and text in this report remain the same.

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[51] Freedom House, *Freedom in the World: Morocco* (2024), https://freedomhouse.org/country/morocco/freedom-world/2024

[52] Freedom House, *Freedom in the World: Morocco* (2024), https://freedomhouse.org/country/morocco/freedom-world/2024

[53] Ibrahim Index of African Governance, *Morocco 2021, Overall Governance, https://iiag.online/data.html?loc=MA&meas=GOVERNANCE-PRI&view=overview&subview=absoluteTrends* [45] University of Minnesota, *Ratification of International Human Rights Treaties – Morocco* (2023), http://hrlibrary.umn.edu/research/ratification-morocco.html

[54] University of Minnesota, *Ratification of International Human Rights Treaties – Morocco* (2023), http://hrlibrary.umn.edu/research/ratification-morocco.html

[55] International Justice Resource Center, *Courts and Monitoring Bodies – Middle East and North Africa*, (2023), https://ijrcenter.org/regional/middle-east-and-north-africa/

[56] International Justice Resource Center, *Country Factsheet Series – Morocco* (September 15, 2017), https://ijrcenter.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/11/Morocco.pdf

OECD AI Principles / G20 AI Guidelines

While Morocco is not a member of the OECD and has not endorsed the OECD AI Principles,[57] the OECD does track Morocco on its Policy Observatory site. [58] [59] Under each principle, the site includes the previously mentioned "ecosystem dedicated to artificial intelligence"[60] as encompassing the establishment of "a strategy and national roadmap for developing an AI Ecosystem."[61] A second initiative is contained under Principle 1.1 – Inclusive growth, sustainable development, and well-being.[62] This references the Artificial Intelligence research taking place at Hassan II University of Casablanca under the Al Khawarizmi 2020 program.[63]

UNESCO Recommendations on the Ethics of AI

Morocco has been a member state of UNESCO since October 1975.[64] It is one of the 193 countries that endorsed the UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence in November 2021.[65] Morocco participated on the 24-member expert group that prepared the text of the recommendation and was one of the 5 African countries that "contributed comments on the first draft of the recommendation." [66]

In a March 2022 meeting, Morocco's Minister Delegate for digital transition and Administrative Reform said that a "commission will be set up to establish a road map to implement the provisions of the recommendation on the ethics of AI." [67] Beginning in 2023,

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[57] OECD, *The state of implementation of the OECD AI Principles four years on* (October 2023), https://www.oecd-ilibrary.org/science-and-technology/the-state-of-implementation-of-the-oecd-ai-principles- four-years-on_835641c9-en

[58] OECD.AI, Governments that have committed to the AI Principles (2021). https://wp.oecd.ai/app/uploads/2022/07/oecd-worldmap-July-2022-1024x652.png

[59] OECD.AI, National AI Policies & Strategies (2021). https://oecd.ai/en/dashboards/overview

[60] Digital Development Agency, *Ecosystem Dedicated to Artificial Intelligence* (2021), https://www.add.gov.ma/ecosysteme-dedie-a-lintelligence-artificielle-prioritaire

[61] OECD.AI, *Morocco – Strategy for Developing an AI Ecosystem* (2021), https://oecd.ai/en/dashboards/policy-initiatives/http:%2F%2Faipo.oecd.org%2F2021-data-policyInitiatives-27136

[62] OECD.AI, *Morocco – R&D Centre Specialised in ICT and Artificial Intelligence* (2022), https://oecd.ai/en/dashboards/policy-initiatives/http:%2F%2Faipo.oecd.org%2F2021-data-policyInitiatives-16699

[63] Hassan II University of Casablanca, *Al Khawarizmi 2020 (Artificial Intelligence)* (2023), https://www.univh2c.ma/projets-de-recherche/#10

[64] UNESCO, *Morocco* (2023), https://whc.unesco.org/en/statesparties/ma

[65] UNESCO, *UNESCO Member States Adopt the First Ever Global Agreement on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence* (April 21, 2022), https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/unesco-member-states-adopt-first-ever- global-agreement-ethics-artificial-intelligence

[66] DiploFoundation, *Stronger Digital Voices from Africa – Building African Digital Foreign Policy and Diplomacy* (November 2022), https://www.diplomacy.edu/wp-content/uploads/2023/01/African-digital-foreign-policy_En.pdfion

[67] Oumaima Latrech, *Morocco, UNESCO Pledge to Strengthen Artificial Intelligence Ethics* (March 26, 2022), https://www.moroccoworldnews.com/2022/03/347908/morocco-unesco-pledge-to-strengthen-artificial- intelligence-ethics

Morocco was selected as part of a pilot group of countries developing legislative, regulatory, and institutional changes to best align themselves with the UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI.[68]

p. 9 Add "Beginning in 2023, Morocco was selected as part of a pilot group of countries developing legislative, regulatory, and institutional changes to best align themselves with the UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI."

→ Justification: Updated to include 2023 information about pilot working group. Added citation (61) as well. Note there are informal articles about Morocco's presentation of this pilot group's findings in 2024, but they were not readily accessible on public sources.

Additionally, in 2021, in UNESCO's AI Needs Assessment Survey, 32 countries in Africa had identified institutional capacity building for AI as a key priority.[69] At the UNESCO General Conference 2023, 194 countries decided to designate *Ai Movement* in Morocco as the first UNESCO-affiliated Center in Africa.[70] *Ai Movement* will work on:

1. Capacity building for policymakers, public administrations
2. Innovation and entrepreneurship through its programs like African Women in Tech
3. Educational programs at Masters and Doctoral level, as well as programs for Executives to support African businesses
4. Creating research cooperation within Africa and beyond

Evaluation

Though there hasn't been any official word on the matter, Morocco's AI trajectory points to a strategic shift in the direction of a National Strategy for Artificial Intelligence. With several efforts and approvals, Morocco has shown that it is a progressive country in recent years. Particularly, even in situations when the human rights environment is not ideal, the Data Protection National Commission's active oversight offers a layer of safety in areas of AI research. Morocco has demonstrated its commitment to ethical AI and data protection standards by endorsing the UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI and by signing Convention 108 and the Protocol. The nation's co-sponsorship of

[68] UNESCO, *Implementation of the Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence (AI)* (2023), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000387369
[69] UNESCO, *Artificial Intelligence Needs Assessment Survey in Africa* (2021), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000375322
[70] UNESCO, *Category 2 Institutes and Centres, proposals for designation, Part II: Moroccan International Centre for Artificial Intelligence (AI Movement), Morocco* (September 2023), https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000386790_eng

Resolution 2023 on Generative Artificial Intelligence Systems at the World Privacy Assembly demonstrates its active involvement in forming global AI policy.

The United States' cooperation with Morocco in the presentation of the first-ever UN General Assembly resolution on the use of artificial intelligence on March 15, 2024, further demonstrated the country's active involvement in forming the global governance of AI. This achievement highlights Morocco's dedication to global cooperation and its understanding of the significance of creating precise standards and rules for the ethical and responsible application of AI worldwide. Morocco's introduction of projects centered around artificial intelligence (AI) in higher education is indicative of its progressive outlook and goal to leverage AI technologies. All of these changes point to Morocco's awareness of the critical role artificial intelligence (AI) will play in determining the course of the future and its deliberate attempts to establish itself as a player in the international AI arena.

Metrics

Q1. Has the country endorsed the OECD AI Principles?	N
Q2. Is the country implementing the OECD AI Principles?	P
Q3. Has the country endorsed the Universal Declaration of Human Rights?	Y
Q4. Is the country implementing the Universal Declaration for Human Rights?	P
Q5. Has the country established a process for meaningful public participation in the development of a national AI Policy?	P
Q6. Are materials about the country's AI policies and practices readily available to the public?	N
Q7. Does the country have an independent (agency/mechanism) for AI oversight?	P
Q8. Do the following goals appear in the national AI policy: "Fairness," "Accountability," "Transparency," ("Rule of Law, ") ("Fundamental Rights")? [implementation? = legal force? = enforcement?]	N
Q9. Has the country by law established a right to Algorithmic Transparency? [GDPR? / COE+?]	Y
Q10. Has the country endorsed the UNESCO Recommendation on AI Ethics?	Y

Q11. Is the country implementing the UNESCO Recommendation on AI Ethics?	P
Q12: Has the country's Data Protection Agency sponsored the 2018 GPA Resolution on AI and Ethics, the 2020 GPA Resolution on AI and Accountability, the 2022 GPA Resolution on AI and Accountability and the 2023 Resolution on Generative AI Systems? (Only for this question: 0/4=N; $\frac{1}{4}$, $\frac{2}{4}$ or $\frac{3}{4}$=P; 4/4=Y)	P